

AIWA RS-X 150 Natsukasii Pro

Leaves a solid mark

It won't be wrong to say that there is an abundance of Bluetooth speakers in the Indian market. With brands like AIWA, Marshall, JBL, Sony, LG, and the like bringing in offerings across budgets, it can be really tricky for buyers to make the right choice that would get them the best for their money. Even inside a budget segment, the positioning of products is so different that, at times, it becomes really difficult to pick the right one.

When the AIWA RS-X150 Natsukasii Pro speaker showed up at the Digit Test Centre, I wanted to know what the positioning of the speaker was. This is because even AIWA has offerings across budget segments. I spoke with Mr Ajay Mehta, Managing Director at AIWA India, to understand what the brand has been gunning for in India. With some clarity after the discussion, I dived into our testing, putting the speaker through our test process to see if it lives up to its price tag of ₹27,990. The speaker is priced pretty close to some offerings by brands like Sonos, LG, and Sony, which have fared pretty well in our testing in the past. So, the competition was going to be stiff for the Natsukasii Pro.

Here's a look at how the AIWA RS-X150 Natsukasii Pro fared in our testing and whether it was able to live up to the expectations set by its pricier cousin, the MI-X330 Meteor, which had won the 2022 Digit Zero1 Award for being the Best Bluetooth speaker –

BUILD AND DESIGN

The AIWA RS-X150 Natsukasii Pro's design can be described in a single phrase – all that glitters is not gold.



When you look at the speaker from afar, you will instantly draw parallels with offerings by a closely competing brand *cough* Marshall *cough*. If you were to slap the other brand's logo onto this, you could easily pass this as that brand's product.

I love the retro look it sports, and the colour choices made by AIWA's designers fit in perfectly!

But, on closer inspection, you start to see the differences. Let's start with the control cluster at the top. To my disappointment, it is made of plastic and the kind that doesn't fit into the premium build and design of the speaker. The dials have a nice step-by-step tactile feel to them, but apart from that, there's nothing to write home about. For the price that one is paying, even a polished stainless steel casing for the dials and buttons would have been adequate. It is not like AIWA could not do this. The on-off flick switch that is there in the same cluster is metallic. And the difference in feel is very apparent. If you look past it, the control cluster has a solid selection of things that you can alter from there. For someone like me,

who is a stickler for physical controls, this is a huge win!

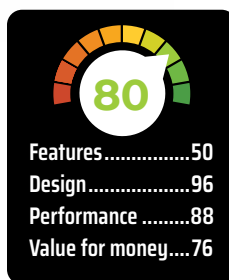
As for the rest of the speaker, on the front, you get a small AIWA logo on the fabric front of the speaker, which looks and feels great! The body of the speaker is covered in a leather-like material. Such materials, in my experience, are prone to fraying if you don't take good care. So, keep that in mind. The included handle also has the same material on the top, with the inside being velvet. It hooks onto the speaker using the two metal studs, which are sturdy, and you never feel that they'll detach from the speaker.

Sometimes in speakers, the lack of robust feet can be a killer for the overall experience, especially for something that can get as loud as

this one. However, when I was playing the speaker at about full volumes, there was minimal rattling. Props to the engineers at AIWA for that!

What you are getting for the money that you are spending on the AIWA RS-X150 Natsukasii Pro, in terms of the overall

build and design of the speaker, is adequate for the price. Nothing out of the ordinary. I would have loved it if the speaker had a metallic control cluster. But the fact that it is plastic was a bummer for me, especially given that the rest of the speaker was solid!



FEATURES

As was the case with the last AIWA speaker I tested, the features on the AIWA RS-X150 Natsukasii Pro are limited but robust. Let's start with the connectivity and related features. One of the best things about this speaker is the ample amount of ports and connectivity options that it comes with. On the speaker, you will find – AUX-IN, USB, micro-SD and Bluetooth connectivity. Many Bluetooth speakers these days are limited to two connectivity options, AUX and Bluetooth. So, having an additional